

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

AI

AI IN THE MANAGER'S WORK, WITHOUT ILLUSIONS

What the experiments measure when people work with AI, where it helps and where it misleads, and what the manager has to set before the team relies on it.



19%

more time was needed by experienced developers for tasks on which they could use AI. They believed AI had made them 20% faster.

METR, 2025

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In this issue

Half of US employees now use AI in their work at least now and then. This issue is about the distance between what AI seems to do and what can be measured, and about the manager who has to decide in that distance.

In 2025 experienced developers believed AI had made them faster, while the clock said slower. Other experiments found large gains, mostly for newer people and for tasks inside what researchers call the jagged frontier. Gallup finds that use grows faster than plans, and that the manager's support goes together with whether it helps.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Felt faster, measured slower

In early 2025 the research group METR ran a randomised experiment: 16 experienced developers, 246 real tasks in projects they knew well. Each task was randomly assigned to be done with AI tools or without them.

24%

faster: what the
developers expected
before

20%

faster: what they believed
afterwards

19%

slower: what was
measured

Experts in economics and machine learning had forecast tasks almost 40% shorter. METR calls the result a snapshot of early-2025 tools in one setting, and in 2026 it began changing its study design because the tools and the way people use them had changed. What has not changed is the gap between the feeling and the clock.



2023

Customer support:
14% more cases
solved per hour with
AI.



2023

Consultants: big gains
inside the frontier,
worse results outside
it.



2025

Developers: 19%
slower, with the
feeling of being
faster.



2026

Gallup: half of US
employees use AI at
work.

OUR READING

The feeling of speed is not a measurement. Before a team changes how it works, someone has to measure the work, not the impression.

Sources: METR, 2025; Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023; Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023; Gallup, 2026

THE NUMBERS

Half use it, few have a plan

Since 2023 Gallup has asked US employees how often they use AI in their role. Use has more than doubled; the plans have not kept up.

USE AI AT WORK A FEW TIMES A YEAR OR MORE, US, SECOND QUARTER



44%

say their organisation has
begun to integrate AI (2025)

22%

say a clear plan was
communicated to them
(2025)

Frequent use, a few times a week or more, rose from 11% in 2023 to 30% in May 2026; 15% now use AI every day.

OUR READING

Use grows from the bottom; the plan has to come from the top. In between stands the manager, who sees both.

Sources: Gallup, 2025; Gallup, 2026

THE MODEL

The jagged frontier

In 2023 Harvard Business School and BCG gave 758 consultants GPT-4 for realistic tasks. The researchers call the line between what AI does well and badly a jagged frontier: tasks that look equally hard can fall on either side of it.

Inside the frontier

12.2% more tasks completed

25.1% faster

Over 40% higher quality

Outside the frontier

19 percentage points less likely to be correct

The help of AI made the result worse

How hard the task looked did not tell the side

In customer support, 5,179 agents with an AI assistant solved 14% more cases per hour on average. The newest and least skilled gained 34%; the most experienced, almost nothing.

OUR READING

AI helps most where the task is known and the result can be checked. Outside the frontier it needs someone who knows the work well enough to see the mistake.

Sources: Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023; Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023

The frontier is the researchers' term; applying it to a manager's tasks is our reading.

More in the essay

From retail to logistics and hospitality: the industry changes, the management problems do not

THE MANAGER'S PART

Where the manager comes in

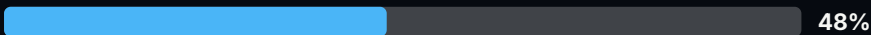
In Gallup's 2026 data, the manager's support goes together with whether AI use helps the team or stays a private habit.

ENGAGED EMPLOYEES, US, 2026

Frequent use, a clear plan and the manager's support together



The manager actively supports the team's AI use



Without that support



36%

strongly agree that their manager supports the team's AI use (organisations integrating AI, May 2026)

40%

received "workslop" in the past month (1,150 US employees, 2025)

Workslop is work made with AI that looks useful but lacks substance. The person who sent it saves time; the person who receives it has to interpret, correct or redo it.

OUR READING

The manager sets the standard: what AI may do, who checks it and what counts as finished. Without a standard, one person's speed becomes the next person's rework.

Sources: Gallup, Employee Engagement Remains Flat as AI Adoption Accelerates, 2026; Gallup, Indicator: Artificial Intelligence, 2026; Kate Niederhoffer et al., Harvard Business Review, 2025

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Measure before you believe

In 2025 a preliminary MIT NANDA report said 95% of organisations saw no measurable return from generative AI. It rested on 52 interviews, 153 survey answers from four conferences and over 300 public projects; many headlines turned it into “95% of pilots fail”. Neither a headline nor a feeling replaces measuring your own work.

1

Choose one task

Repeated, known, and with a result you can check.

2

Measure it without AI

Two weeks: time per task and the corrections it needs.

3

Measure it with AI

The same task and the same check, including the time spent checking.

4

Decide with the numbers

Keep, change or stop, and write down who checks.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, THE WEEKLY SHIFT REPORT

Without AI 3 h, 4 corrections

With AI 1 h 10 min + 30 min checking, 1 correction

The saving is real but smaller than it feels: 1 h 20 min a week. The numbers are invented.

Source: Aditya Challapally et al., MIT NANDA, 2025

The steps and the example are the editors'.

[More in the essay](#)

KPIs do not improve in Excel

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The AI task card

One card for every task you hand to AI. Fill it in with the person who does the task, and look at it again after a month.

01 The task what, how often, for whom

02 Inside or outside the frontier? can a mistake be seen quickly?

03 What AI does, what the person does

04 Who checks, and how before it leaves the team

05 Measured before and after time and corrections

06 Decision and review date keep, change, stop

A practice proposed by the editors. Do not put personal or confidential data into public AI tools, or on the card.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity

METR, 2025

<https://metr.org/blog/2025-07-10-early-2025-ai-experienced-os-dev-study/>

AI Use at Work Has Nearly Doubled in Two Years

Gallup, 2025

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/691643/work-nearly-doubled-two-years.aspx>

Indicator: Artificial Intelligence

Gallup, 2026

<https://www.gallup.com/699797/indicator-artificial-intelligence.aspx>

Navigating the Jagged Technological Frontier

Fabrizio Dell'Acqua, Edward McFowland III, Ethan Mollick et al., Harvard Business School, 2023

<https://papers.ssrn.com/abstract=4573321>

Generative AI at Work

Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li & Lindsey Raymond, NBER, 2023

<https://www.nber.org/papers/w31161>

Employee Engagement Remains Flat as AI Adoption Accelerates

Gallup, 2026

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/712433/employee-engagement-remains-flat-adoption-accelerates.aspx>

AI-Generated “Workslop” Is Destroying Productivity

Kate Niederhoffer et al., Harvard Business Review, 2025

<https://hbr.org/2025/09/ai-generated-workslop-is-destroying-productivity>

The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025

Aditya Challapally et al., MIT NANDA, 2025

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html